

Affect Heuristic

What Is It?

People often make decisions based on how they *feel* rather than what they *know*. This mental shortcut relies on emotional impressions to guide judgment quickly — especially when time or effort is limited.

For example, you might avoid a restaurant just because it looks slightly unclean, even if its reviews are excellent.

History

The concept was introduced by psychologists **Paul Slovic, Melissa Finucane, Ellen Peters, and Donald MacGregor** in the **early 2000s**.

Their research showed that emotions often dominate rational thinking in decision-making, influencing everything from risk perception to consumer behavior.

The Psychology Behind It

- Emotions act as a **filter** that speeds up decision-making.
 - Positive feelings create **perceived safety and trust**, while negative feelings trigger **avoidance or caution**.
 - Under pressure, the brain relies more on emotional signals than logic.
 - This helps in quick reactions but can also lead to **biased or impulsive** choices.
-

Why It Matters

- Helps users make quick judgments
 - Shapes trust and brand preference
 - Can lead to impulsive decisions
 - May distort risk perception or accuracy
-

How to Apply It

- Use **emotion-driven design** to guide attention and trust
 - Pair emotional appeal with **transparent facts** and **clear outcomes**
 - Avoid manipulative or fear-based triggers
 - Use **colors, tone, and imagery** that match desired emotions
-

Theory in Action

- **Nike** evokes ambition and identity through emotional storytelling rather than product specs.
 - **Disneyland** uses nostalgia and joy to create lasting emotional bonds with visitors.
-

Final Thought

Emotion moves users before logic does.

Design experiences that **feel right first**, then **prove right** through clarity and transparency.